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Awesome Mnemonics - Quick Reference Card

Print this page for your desk or on-call kit

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CRISIS RESPONSE (Production Down)

STOP → TRACE → DEBUG → 8D

STOP (2-5 min) - S - Step back - T - Take a deep breath - O - Observe what is happening - P - Pull back and put things in perspective

TRACE (Network/System) - T - Test connectivity - R - Review logs and metrics - A - Analyze packet captures - C - Check configurations - E - Escalate with documented evidence

DEBUG (Analysis) - D - Define the problem - E - Examine error messages/logs - B - Break down into components - U - Understand data flow - G - Generate hypothesis and test

8D Approach (Resolution) - D1 - Form a team - D2 - Describe the problem - D3 - Interim Containment Action - D4 - Root Cause Analysis (use 5 Whys) - D5 - Permanent Corrective Actions - D6 - Implement & Validate - D7 - Prevent reoccurrence - D8 - Congratulate your team and close the loop (closure & celebration)

QUICK DECISIONS

IDEA → DICE → FATE (10-30 min)

IDEA - I - Identify problem - D - Develop Solution - E - Execute Solution - A - Assess Solution

DICE (Check Blockers) - D - Delay - I - Incompetence - C - Conflict - E - External factors

FATE (Resource Check) - F - Funding - A - Allocation of resources - T - Time - E - Expertise

CONFLICT RESOLUTION

WAIT → **BREATHE** → **PAUSE** → **RACI** (5-20 min)

WAIT - “Why am I talking?” - Listen first

BREATHE - B - Breathe deeply and slowly - R - Remain rational and listen - E - Empathize with the other person’s problem - A - Ask questions to understand - T - Take a break if needed - H - Hold back from reacting - E - Express yourself calmly

PAUSE - P - Put things in perspective - A - Acknowledge your feelings and theirs - U - Understand you don’t have to react immediately - S - Step Away from the situation - E - Evaluate options and plan

RACI (Clarify Roles) - R - Responsible (does the work) - A - Accountable (final approval) - C - Consulted (provides input) - I - Informed (kept updated)

ROOT CAUSE ANALYSIS

ICEBERG → **5 Whys** → **PADDER** (1-2 hours)

ICEBERG - I - Identify issue(s) - C - Collect data and analyze situation - E - Examine possible (root) causes - B - Brainstorm solutions - E - Execute solution(s) - R - Review, evaluate, and adjust solutions - G - Gather feedback

5 Whys - Keep asking “Why?” until root cause identified - Usually 3-5 iterations

Ishikawa (Fishbone) - State problem (head); choose categories (e.g. 6 M’s); brainstorm causes (bones); use 5 Whys on branches

A3 Problem Solving - One-page: Background, Current state, Goal, Root cause (5 Whys/Ishikawa), Countermeasures, Plan

PADDER - P - Pinpoint problem - A - Analyze data and look for patterns - D - Develop solution & consider other ways—try to have more than one option - D - Design action plan - E - Execute action plan & Monitor Results - R - Reevaluate and refine plan as needed

STRESS MANAGEMENT

PACE → **ARIES** → **CALM** (10-15 min immediate, 2-4 weeks long-term)

PACE (Immediate) - P - Physical activity - A - Avoiding unhealthy behaviors
- C - Coping skills - E - Emotional awareness

ARIES (Lifestyle) - A - Avoid unnecessary stress - R - Relax and take breaks
- I - Incorporate physical activity - E - Eat a healthy diet - S - Sleep well

CALM (Mental Framework) - C - Confidence: Believe in your abilities - A - Awareness: Stay conscious of thoughts/feelings - L - Logic: Use rational thinking
- M - Mindfulness: Practice being present

INFRASTRUCTURE DESIGN

SCALE → **SWOT** → **PESTEL** → **SET**

SCALE - S - Security by design - C - Capacity planning - A - Automation-first
- L - Load balancing - E - Error handling/resilience

SWOT (Evaluate Design) - S - Strengths - W - Weaknesses - O - Opportunities
- T - Threats

PESTEL (External Factors) - P - Political - E - Economic - S - Sociocultural
- T - Technological - E - Environmental - L - Legal

SET Triangle (Pick 2) - Good / Fast / Cheap - The third is what you won't get

QUICK SITUATION GUIDE

Situation	Use This	Time
Immediate crisis	IDEA → STOP	2-5 min
Root cause needed	ICEBERG + 5 Whys	30-60 min
Team conflict	BREATHE → PAUSE → WAIT	5-10 min
Strategic planning	PREPARE + SWOT	1-2 hours
System design	SCALE + PESTEL	Planning phase
Technical debugging	TRACE → DEBUG	Variable
Stress overload	PACE → ARIES → CALM	10-15 min

NETWORK TROUBLESHOOTING

TRACE - T - Test connectivity (ping, traceroute) - R - Review logs and metrics
- A - Analyze packet captures - C - Check configurations - E - Escalate with documented evidence

KEY PRINCIPLES

1. **Don't skip steps** - Each mnemonic builds on the previous one
 2. **Document at each stage** - Your insights inform the next step
 3. **Know when to branch** - If simple becomes complex, escalate
 4. **Always start with STOP** if emotionally activated
 5. **Use RACI** to clarify roles and prevent confusion
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Full guide: <https://github.com/StewAlexander-com/Awesome-Mnemonics>

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